all nuclear weapons states but is an especially worrying problem for any state that abjured delegating authority to subordinate commanders. Both the US and the UK adopted pre-delegation, while the Soviets did not (at least with their ICBMs and strategic bombers). This is further discussed in chapter seven.

The goal of USAF leaders was simple. If war came, it was their responsibility to prevent – or at least limit – damage to the United States. SIOP-62 was designed for a single 'spasm' launch, either in retaliation against, or in pre-emption, of a Soviet attack. While the Joint Chiefs planned for retaliation, they fully intended to get their retaliation in first. In other words, the SIOP was intended by its authors to deliver a nuclear first strike (later defined by Robert McNamara as 'a nuclear attack so powerful as to leave one's opponents with forces which are insufficient to inflict substantial damage on the attacker').[32] For many years, senior USAF officers believed they could win a nuclear war (by striking first), though they recognised US casualties were inevitable. The Joint Chiefs noted there was a 'general consensus' that a nuclear exchange 'would leave the US in a seriously damaged condition, with many millions of casualties and little immediate war supporting capability [but] the US would continue to exist as an organised and viable nation, and ultimately would prevail, whereas the USSR would not.'[33] The aim was to 'engage, survive and prevail if … deterrence fails'.[34]

In *Dr Strangelove*, when General Turgidson tries to persuade President Muffley to launch a pre-emptive nuclear attack, he suggests that with 'an immediate and co-ordinated missile attack on their airfields and missile bases, we stand a damn good chance of catching them with their pants down,' and destroy ninety per cent of Soviet nuclear capabilities. 'We would therefore prevail and suffer only modest and acceptable civilian casualties from their remaining force, which would be badly damaged and completely lack the degree of coordination necessary for a decent and balanced striking force.'[35] General Turgidson explains what he means by 'modest and acceptable casualties' when he tells President Muffley, 'I'm not saying we wouldn't get our hair mussed, Mister President, but I do say not more than ten to twenty million dead depending on the breaks.'[36]